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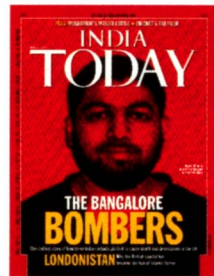
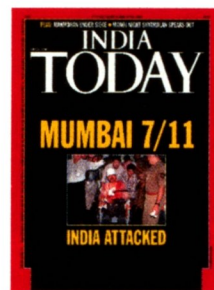
On a TV channel covering the terror attacks in Jaipur, a survivor was describing how the sole earning member of their family had been killed. "They (the terrorists) did not kill one, they killed nine." The wife, five children and their aged grandparents were dependant on the earnings of a rickshaw puller for survival. When you hear such heart-breaking stories, the question you ask is "why?" What twisted mind would destroy entire families who have no connection with the imaginary jihad they have launched? There is another question: Why can't it be stopped? Obviously not entirely—India is a prime target for state-sponsored terrorism from across the border—but at least contained?

Since 1998, there have been 30 major terrorist-related incidents in India. Despite that, the country remains a soft state. We have lived with terror longer than most democracies and yet terrorists are able to strike at will. Clearly, our anti-terrorism apparatus is incapable of tackling the threat, of gathering proper intelligence and ferreting out the sleeper cells. Our response to attacks has been so Kashmir-centric that we have left the rest of the country dangerously vulnerable.

I've been to the US often since 9/11 and the security procedures there are irksome but no one complains, pulls rank or jumps the queue. On each visit, I find improvements in procedure and technology. They had one catastrophic terror strike in September 2001, and none since. They did what was required: set up Homeland Security to coordinate intelligence, beefed up electronic surveillance and, in a country where personal freedom is cherished, they introduced security measures that were draconian. It was the need of the hour and every American fell in line.

Here, we have multiple agencies engaged in turf battles, more money spent on appeasing votebanks than counter-terror and a lack of ground-level intelligence about potential threats. Last week, I was in Srinagar where I was briefed by security officials. Their analysis was incisive in looking at the roots of terrorism in India and had a fascinating set of solutions. When I asked one why his superiors did not act on his inputs, his response was a shrug. It was a telling comment on the way our counter-terror apparatus is riven by hierarchy and insularity. Our cover story examines the question: why can't we stop it? We analyse the pattern of terror strikes, the causes of intelligence failure and speak to experts to examine what needs to be done as opposed to the knee-jerk response we are all familiar with. India's democracy is too precious to be made hostage to cliché-ridden vote-hungry politicians and incompetent, ill-equipped intelligence agencies.

Aroon Purie
(Aroon Purie)



Our July 2006 (top) and July 2007 covers